feral creative

Getting Motoproponent to 1,000 subscribers

Written for Jeffrey, August 2026. The goal, in his words: **1,000 subscribers before 28 February 2031—retirement day.**[1] That gives us about four and a half years.

You have almost certainly worked out most of what follows already—you have been running the channel and I have not. Treat this as me writing down my assumptions so you can correct the ones that are wrong, rather than as advice you asked for. There is one genuine surprise in it, in the next section, and the rest is bookkeeping. Every number is sourced in the notes at the end so you can check my work.

The target is really two numbers, not one

To turn on ad revenue, YouTube asks for **1,000 subscribers *and* 4,000 hours of watch time in the previous 12 months.**[2]

The second number behaves differently from the first, and that is the part worth flagging. Subscribers are cumulative—once someone subscribes they count forever. Watch hours are a rolling twelve-month window that keeps moving, so hours earned in 2027 have expired by 2029. They cannot be banked early. They have to be earned in the year leading up to the day you want to get paid.[2]

So hitting 1,000 subscribers is not the same as being able to monetize. Better to know that now than in 2030.

The subscriber half is the easier half

1,000 subscribers over 54 months is about **19 a month.**[3]

4,000 watch hours inside a single year is the harder ask. Roughly: if a typical viewer watches six minutes, that is around 40,000 views across the year.[4] That is the number I would plan against.

There is an earlier milestone worth aiming at first

Before full monetization there is a lower tier: **500 subscribers, 3,000 watch hours in 12 months, and 3 public uploads in the last 90 days.** It unlocks fan funding—memberships, Super Thanks, tips—but not ad revenue. You graduate to full monetization automatically, without reapplying.[5]

This is the one I would actually aim at. It arrives years sooner and it starts earning.

Long videos over Shorts, for a specific reason

The Shorts route to monetization needs 10 million Shorts views in 90 days, which is not a realistic path here.[2] The part that is easy to miss: watch time from Shorts **does not count** toward the 4,000 hours at all.[2] Twelve minutes of a touring video is twelve minutes; three Shorts is close to nothing that counts.

Shorts are still useful for putting your face in front of strangers. They just are not the thing being measured.

Where a small channel can beat a big one

The larger moto channels will out-produce you, but only because they have more time and better gear, and they will seem more natural on camera because they have done it a few hundred more times. Both of those close with practice and neither is a real moat—you will get there.

What they cannot copy in the meantime is that you are actually living the specific thing: an electric motorcycle as a daily Bay Area commute, what the range really is, where you charge on a day ride, what a newcomer gets wrong in the first month. A big generalist

channel covers electric bikes occasionally. You are one.

That matters for the watch-hour half specifically. A video that answers a question someone typed keeps finding viewers for years, while a ride vlog is mostly watched the week it goes up. That is how hours accumulate while you sleep. In the short term, specificity is the thing to beat them on.

The one scheduling constraint that is not a matter of taste

Upload rhythm is your call. But the 500-subscriber tier requires 3 public uploads within a 90-day window, so a gap longer than that has a concrete cost, not just a momentum cost.[5]

What the website is for

Do not expect the site to bring you subscribers—that is not its job.

Its job is to be the one link that always works and always points at the channel: Instagram bio, email signature, anywhere you introduce yourself. It also means we can see how many people actually make the trip from Instagram to YouTube, which we cannot measure if you link the channel directly.

Instagram's job is finding strangers

Instagram is good at reach and bad at sending people anywhere, since captions do not produce clickable links—the bio link is the reliable path out.[6] So the chain is: Instagram finds people, the bio link sends them to the site, the site sends them to the channel.

The only thing I would add is that I would rather see two accounts fed properly than five going stale.

Four things to do now

1. **Put `motoproponent.com` in your Instagram bio link.** A minute of work, and the highest-value item here.
2. **Add `motoproponent.com` as the first link on your YouTube channel** (Studio → Customization → Basic info → Links).
3. **Aim at 500 subscribers and 3,000 watch hours first**, not 1,000.
4. **Don't let 90 days pass without an upload**, for the reason above.

One standing caveat: YouTube has revised these thresholds before and may well do it again between now and 2031, so none of the numbers above should be treated as fixed for four years.[7]

NOTES

1. Jeffrey's own words, relayed 10 August 2026: "Right now it just about getting the Youtube channel to 1000 subscribers before Feb 28, 2031. (Retirement day)." ↩
2. "YouTube Partner Program overview & eligibility," YouTube Help. Full monetization requires 1,000 subscribers plus either 4,000 valid public watch hours in the previous 12 months or 10 million valid public Shorts views in the previous 90 days. The same page states that watch time from Shorts in the Shorts Feed does not count toward the 4,000 hours, and that private, unlisted and deleted content is excluded. https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/72851 ↩ ↩2 ↩3 ↩4
3. My arithmetic, not YouTube's: August 2026 to February 2031 is roughly 54 months, and 1,000 ÷ 54 ≈ 18.5 subscribers per month. ↩
4. My arithmetic, and illustrative only: 4,000 hours is 240,000 minutes, so at an average six minutes watched per view it takes about 40,000 views. The real figure moves with your actual average view duration, which you can read in YouTube Studio. ↩
5. "Overview of the expanded YouTube Partner Program," YouTube Help. The lower tier is 500 subscribers plus 3 valid public uploads in the last 90 days, plus either 3,000 valid public watch hours in the last 12 months or 3 million valid public Shorts views in the last 90 days. It grants fan funding and some Shopping features, not ad revenue sharing, and channels move up to full YPP automatically on meeting the higher criteria. https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/13429240 ↩ ↩2
6. "How do I add a website link to my Instagram bio?", Instagram Help Center. https://help.instagram.com/362497417173378. The absence of clickable links in captions is a longstanding platform behaviour rather than a documented policy, and Instagram has been seen testing caption links, so this could change. ↩
7. These thresholds have been revised before—the 500-subscriber tier was itself an expansion announced by YouTube in 2023. Worth re-checking once a year. https://blog.youtube/news-and-events/more-ways-for-creators-to-earn-on-youtube/ ↩